made the cardinals swear to it," Frederick wrote back to al-Kamil's court, upon his arrival in Italy. "So, on these men's oaths . . . a rabble of louts and criminals was led by the nose. When we arrived . . . we found that King John and the Lombards had made hostile raids into our domains, and doubted even the news of our arrival because of what the cardinals had sworn."[1]

When the Lombards and King John found out that the reports of Frederick's death had been exaggerated, they lost heart; and when Frederick appeared on the horizon at the head of a German army, both parties beat a hasty retreat. Gregory IX, left without supporters, was forced to agree to a truce. He lifted the emperor's excommunication; in return, Frederick promised not to take revenge on the agitators.[2]

Frederick's next problem: Germany itself.

He had not been back to Germany, the core of his empire, for over ten years. He had left the country in the care of his young son Henry, crowned king of the Germans in 1222, which meant that Henry's regents had been the de facto rulers for nearly a decade. But in his father's absence, Henry had grown up. He was now nineteen, desperately anxious to be independent.

Realizing that Henry needed reining in, Frederick sent him a message ordering him to attend, in 1231, an imperial diet (a general assembly of all the dukes of Germany, presided over by the emperor) at Ravenna. Immediately, the Lombard League cities banded together and blocked Henry's pathway through the Alps. Henry, without a great deal of regret, sent his apologies to his father.[3]

Frederick replied sharply. He was displeased with reports of Henry's lavish lifestyle, and his tendency to favor court advisors who were hostile to the emperor. He ordered his son to meet him in the north of Italy in 1232. In the meantime he issued a series of imperial decrees reversing Henry's latest decisions.[4]

Henry decided not to push the issue—yet. He met Frederick and took an oath of loyalty to him. But the two men were strangers, and the oath was an empty one.

Frederick chose to view the matter as closed. He sent Henry back to Germany and prepared to visit Sicily, the third of his three kingdoms; it was his birthplace, and the only part of the empire that felt like home. But before he left Italy, he finished putting into place another strategy for dealing with the Italian troubles—one that played to his own natural tendencies and also tied Gregory IX's purposes more closely to his own.

Frederick II had always been inclined to treat heresy as an intensive offense against the empire itself. "To offend the divine majesty," he had